

Week 6 — Becoming a Candidate

Goal: Build the resume and cover letter that get you one of the Week 3 jobs. This week the essay *is* the deliverable — a cover letter is just a persuasive essay with a job on the line.

Part 1: The resume

Build a one-page resume aimed at the technician/entry-level roles on your Week 3 list.

The reframe that makes this work: you are not “an 18-year-old with random jobs.” Those dead-end jobs are raw material. Mine them:

- Showed up on time for X months → *reliability* (genuinely rare; hiring managers care)
- Handled a register / inventory / closing → *accountable for money and process*
- Dealt with angry customers → *stays calm under pressure, communicates clearly*
- Trained a new hire → *leadership, even a little*
- Any fixing, building, assembling, crafting, car work, 3D printing, soldering, gaming-PC building → *this is mechanical/electrical aptitude and it goes ON the resume*

Requirements:

- One page. Clean layout, no photo, no graphics, PDF.
- A 2–3 line summary at the top that says what you’re aiming at: e.g., “*Reliable, mechanically-inclined worker seeking an entry-level technician role while pursuing an engineering degree.*” (Employers with tuition programs *like* seeing the degree goal — you’re exactly who those programs are for.)
- Tailor the skills section to words that actually appear in your Week 3 postings (this is how resume screening works — mirror their vocabulary honestly).
- Get one adult who has hired people to tear it apart, then revise.

Part 2: Cover letter (this week’s essay, 300–400 words)

Pick the **#1 job** on your Week 3 list and write a real cover letter for it.

Structure that works: 1. **Why this company** — one specific thing about what they make/do that genuinely interests you (Week 3 research pays off here; almost no applicant does this) 2. **Why you** — two concrete proof points from your experience (see reframes above) 3. **Where you’re going** — your degree plan, and why that makes you a better hire, not a flight risk: you’re building a career in their industry, and if they have tuition assistance you intend to earn it 4. **Ask for the interview.** Plainly.

Then write a second version for your #2 job. You’ll feel the difference between tailored and generic — that difference is the whole game.

Done when

- ☐ One-page resume done, reviewed by someone who has hired people, revised
- ☐ Two tailored cover letters written
- ☐ Walkthrough conversation done — read the cover letters out loud; if a sentence sounds like nobody would ever say it, rewrite it